

The First Home Buyer's 90-Day Checklist — Western Australia

Everything you need to sort before you sign, in plain English.

Correct as at July 2026. Grant amounts and thresholds are set by government and can change — always confirm current details with RevenueWA (wa.gov.au) before relying on this for a purchase decision. This checklist is general information, not financial or legal advice.

Section 1 — Get Your Foundations Right (Do this first, before house-hunting)

- ☐ [] **Check your borrowing capacity with 2-3 lenders or a mortgage broker.**
- ☐ [] **Check your eligibility for the WA First Home Owner Grant.** Currently **\$10,000** for new homes and substantially renovated homes — **not available for established homes**. Following the May 2026 State Budget, the property price cap increased from **\$750,000 to \$800,000** (for homes south of the 26th parallel — confirm the applicable cap for your specific location, as regional/northern WA settings can differ).
- ☐ [] **Understand the stamp duty (transfer duty) exemption — this applies to both new and established homes.** Following the 7 May 2026 budget changes: **full exemption up to \$600,000** (increased from \$500,000), with a **sliding-scale concession up to \$800,000** (increased from \$700,000).
- ☐ [] **Check vacant land thresholds if building.** The exemption threshold rose from \$350,000 to **\$450,000**, with concessional rates extended to **\$550,000**.
- ☐ [] **Consider the off-the-plan concession if buying pre-construction.** Up to 100% duty relief is available, extended by two years to **30 June 2028**, with more generous terms for eligible contracts entered into on or after 12 March 2026.
- ☐ [] **Look into Keystart**, WA's state-run low-deposit home loan scheme (around 2% deposit) — separate from the FHOG, and worth comparing against a mainstream lender using the federal First Home Guarantee, as Keystart isn't automatically your best or only option.
- ☐ [] **Check the federal First Home Guarantee** (5% deposit, no LMI) — confirm current Perth/regional WA price caps with a participating lender.
- ☐ [] **Get formal pre-approval, not just an estimate.**

Section 2 — While You're Searching

- ☐ [] **Set a firm maximum price** based on your pre-approval.
- ☐ [] **Budget for costs beyond the purchase price:** settlement agent/conveyancer fees, building and pest inspections, loan fees, and moving costs.
- ☐ [] **Understand WA uses "settlement agents" (or solicitors) rather than "conveyancers" in common usage** — functionally similar, but confirm your chosen provider is licensed to act in WA.

Section 3 — Know Your Legal Protections Before You Sign (This Is Different in WA)

- ☐ [] **Understand WA has no statutory cooling-off period at all.** Unlike most other states, once you sign a contract of sale in Western Australia, you are immediately and fully committed — there is no window to change your mind, whether buying at auction or through private treaty.
- ☐ [] **Make every condition explicit in the contract before you sign** — finance approval, building and pest inspection, and any other condition you need must be written into the contract itself, since there's no cooling-off safety net to fall back on if something goes wrong after signing.
- ☐ [] **Get your building and pest inspection arranged and, ideally, completed before you sign**, or ensure a robust inspection condition with a clear timeframe is built into the contract.
- ☐ [] **Have a settlement agent or solicitor review the contract before you sign**, not after — in WA, this review needs to happen pre-signature given the lack of a cooling-off period.

Section 4 — Between Signing and Settlement

- ☐ [] **Confirm building insurance timing with your settlement agent/solicitor.**
- ☐ [] **Finalise unconditional loan approval** well before settlement.
- ☐ [] **Book a pre-settlement inspection** in the days before settlement.
- ☐ [] **Lodge your FHOG application with your home loan application** — don't wait until after settlement; WA guidance specifically recommends applying alongside your loan, and you can also apply directly through the WA Department of Finance within 12 months of settlement if needed.

Section 5 — Common First-Home-Buyer Mistakes to Avoid

- ☐ [] **Don't assume you have a cooling-off period** — this is the single biggest difference between WA and most other Australian states, and it catches buyers out who assume a "standard" grace period applies.
- ☐ [] **Don't sign before your inspection and finance conditions are properly documented in the contract.**
- ☐ [] **Don't assume the FHOG applies to established homes** — it's new/substantially renovated homes only; the stamp duty exemption is what applies to established homes.
- ☐ [] **Don't assume Keystart is automatically your best option** — compare it against mainstream lenders using the First Home Guarantee.

Quick Reference — Western Australia First Home Buyer Support (July 2026)

SUPPORT	AMOUNT / DETAIL	APPLIES TO
First Home Owner Grant	\$10,000	New/substantially renovated homes, cap \$800,000 (south of 26th parallel)
Stamp duty exemption	\$0 duty	New or established homes, ≤\$600,000

Stamp duty concession	Sliding scale	\$600,000–\$800,000
Vacant land exemption	\$0 duty	≤\$450,000
Off-the-plan concession	Up to 100% relief	Extended to 30 June 2028
Cooling-off period	None	No statutory right to withdraw after signing

Sources: RevenueWA (wa.gov.au), WA Department of Finance. Always verify current figures before making a purchase decision.

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